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Political Outsider
Break up Microsoft, and consumers will pay the price

By Mike Talon



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In case you haven't turned on a television, listened to a radio or picked up a newspaper in the last few months, the U.S. Justice Department is about to force Microsoft to split its monopolistic empire into two or three separate companies. This is, of course, in response to Microsoft's domination of the computer software markets for both home and office. While government officials are applauding this move, many computer industry professionals are getting very worried.

One proposal is to break up Microsoft into an operating system company and some "other software" company. Another plan would split Microsoft into three companies: operating systems, applications and browser businesses. This would promptly turn one huge monopolistic company into two or three huge monopolistic companies. True, Bill Gates would only be able to head up one of these units. Which he chooses is irrelevant, however. Gates would still control both. The man's net wealth will not suffer here. Consumer interests, on the other hand, will suffer greatly.

The Justice Department claims that splitting the company will force Microsoft to make all of its products compatible with other software on the market. The logic here is that the companies couldn't share trade secrets between themselves without sharing them with the rest of the market. Therefore, any software manufacturer could get any specification on the Windows line of operating systems.

The reality could be much more harmful to the market. The operating system company would refuse to cooperate with anyone—just as it does now—but with the added blow of no longer cooperating with other Microsoft business units. This would mean that the operating system company's own products wouldn't be fully compatible with Windows anymore—or even less compatible than they are now, depending on your point of view.

Truth be told, Microsoft's "compromise" plan was not a winning solution for anyone but Microsoft. Their idea could basically be boiled down to "We promise we'll play fair from here on out, but I may have my fingers crossed behind my back." Thankfully, the chief judge in the case didn't even give that a second look. Perhaps the only thing more pitiful than the compromise deal was the series of ridiculous

commercials that Gates seemingly produced himself in a bid to clean up his company's image.

One overlooked fact in Washington's whole dog and pony show (Redmond or DC, your choice) is that Microsoft, while a monopoly and unfair competitor, is at least a very public one. In fact, each move it makes is extremely public—whether it be a takeover or the crowding out of competing technology. Many monopolies are so secretive that the public never finds out what's happened until "Who Wants to be a Millionaire" suddenly isn't broadcasting on their cable network. Microsoft, on the other hand, can't do anything without every news outlet in the country broadcasting the move to the masses.

All told, the proposed deal to split up Microsoft seems set to cause a lot more harm than good. It's also taking attention away from monopolies that are truly hurting the consumer. Most of us would agree that our local phone company has been delivering a more painful screwing to the local citizenry than, say, the Windows 2000 system. If Janet Reno could get our phone bills lower than our share of the national debt, we'd all be able to afford the next version of MS Office—even at monopolistic prices.

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